



Rajeev Madhavan with family

bring. From that point on, there was no looking back.

"I thank my stars for coming across Prof. P.S. Bhatt and Ed Vopni, who guided me in the right direction. Vopni's harsh truths opened my eyes. I advise all young managers to be truthful to their employees and let them know how they are performing," he remarks.

Two years into working at BNR, at the age of 25, Rajeev authored a book on Verilog, which went on to become one of the pioneering textbooks on HDL-based logic design, synthesis, and verification.

California calling

Between work, supporting customers, and long hours, Rajeev battled the cold and harsh winters of Ottawa, trying to acclimatise himself to the chill, but to no avail. "My friends tried taking me skating on the Ottawa River several times, but I kept falling while kids skated circles around me," he recalls, laughing it off.

In December 1990, Rajeev attended a conference in California to present a paper. "I loved California. The weather was fantastic, and I called my wife, telling her we should move there," he narrates. On returning to Ottawa, Rajeev told his manager that

he wanted to skip his yearly review as he planned to move to California. His manager, in turn, guided him down the correct route and suggested an assignment from BNR on a joint project with Cadence Design Systems. "He proposed sending me to California for a year and a half so I could decide if I really wanted to move permanently," shares Rajeev.

Around the same time, Rajeev met a venture partner named Lucio Lanza from US Venture Partners, who was funding a company called Epic Design, a major success in chip design automation software. Lanza would discuss business plans with Rajeev due to his strong design background at BNR. The conversations with Lanza intrigued him, sowing the first seeds of pursuing a direction in startups.

Rajeev started working at Cadence as a BNR employee, specifying the needs of BNR for analogue design. He wrote a specification for a product for analogue HDL, which later became a product at Cadence. As he made the decision to move permanently to a California company, Cadence offered him a position to implement the analogue HDL. A year later, as the product was being launched, Rajeev was

sent on a flight to Florida to present the product to Harris Semiconductor. On the way back, Jim Solomon, the founder of Cadence, invited Rajeev to sit next to him. After a few glasses of wine and some questions from Rajeev, Solomon revealed that if he had a second chance at doing things differently, he would have launched the analogue division of Cadence as a startup.

The conversation lit a spark in Rajeev, who realised that pursuing an idea as a startup was possible. He wanted to start his own company. The following week, he decided to work with Vinod Agarwal and formed LogicVision. Solomon tried to warn him against leaving his job, citing that the market for test automation was not very large then. "I had no idea about market size at that time. I was simply driven by the idea of starting something new," reveals Rajeev.

Thus, once again driven by passion and vigour, Rajeev dove headfirst into another challenge. Back home, his mother was furious and could not understand why Rajeev would leave a job at BNR (more than 10,000 employees) for Cadence (800 employees at that time) and give up a good job and stable salary to become an entrepreneur and start a business!

With zero business sense and a singular focus on getting customers to use the software he had created, Rajeev and his co-founders managed to get Apple to use their product. Rajeev and his team spent their mornings working with Apple's team and returned at night to write code. "My wife would bring food, and I would sleep on a pullout couch in the office. There were many days when I did not go home because I was so determined to get things done. This was where I built a work ethic and learnt that making the customer successful was the most important thing," he shares.

After a year, Rajeev concluded